# Guns or Gandhi: Ethnic Elite Composition and Dissident Tactics in Civil Conflicts

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**Abstract**

This paper is very cool blbablalblab

## Contents

# Introduction

Why do some dissident movements pursue their political objectives through nonviolent resistance while others resort to violence? This question has attracted substantial attention in the study of civil resistance and political conflict because the choice of tactics can profoundly affect campaign outcomes, levels of human suffering, and prospects for political change. Research consistently finds that nonviolent campaigns are more likely to succeed than violent ones, yet dissident groups continue to choose violent strategies in many contexts. Understanding the factors that shape this choice therefore remains a central challenge for scholars of contentious politics.

Existing research largely explains campaign tactics through political opportunities. Dissident organizations are assumed to select the strategy that offers the highest probability of achieving their goals, given the political environment they face. Nonviolent resistance is generally expected to be more attractive when campaigns can mobilize broad participation, induce elite defections, avoid severe repression, and obtain concessions from incumbents. Violent tactics become relatively more attractive when these opportunities are absent. While this literature has generated important insights, less attention has been paid to the factors that structure these political opportunities in the first place.

This paper argues that the ethnic composition of ruling elites may be one such factor. Ethnic divisions within governing coalitions can increase the likelihood of defections, complicate repression, and encourage negotiated concessions. These mechanisms should alter the strategic environment facing dissidents and influence whether nonviolent or violent tactics appear more effective. Specifically, we argue that greater ethnic fragmentation and a more equal distribution of power among ethnic groups in the ruling coalition increase the attractiveness of nonviolent resistance relative to violent contention.

To evaluate this argument, we combine data on maximalist dissident campaigns from the NAVCO 2.1 dataset with measures of ethnic power relations from the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) project. Using random effects logistic regression models, we examine whether variation in the ethnic structure of ruling elites predicts campaign tactic choice across a global sample of campaigns between 1945 and 2013.

Contrary to theoretical expectations, the results provide little evidence that ethnic fragmentation or the distribution of power among ruling ethnic groups systematically influences whether dissidents adopt violent or nonviolent tactics. These null findings remain robust across several alternative specifications and subsamples. The findings suggest that while elite cohesion may matter for campaign success and regime stability, ethnic elite composition alone does not appear to shape the initial strategic choice between violence and nonviolence.

The paper contributes to the literature on civil resistance and ethnic politics in two ways. First, it extends political opportunity approaches to campaign tactic choice by linking them to the ethnic structure of ruling elites. Second, by finding no consistent relationship between ethnic elite composition and tactical choice, it identifies an important boundary condition on theories that emphasize elite fragmentation as a source of political opportunity. More broadly, the results suggest that the determinants of campaign tactics may lie elsewhere than in the ethnic configuration of political power.

# Violent and Non-violent Campaign Choice

Previous literature has established that civil resistance campaigns and violent campaigns are often a strategic choice made before the campaign (Schock 2005). One strand of this literature emphasizes the role of political opportunities in shaping these choices (). Campaign leaders evaluate the political environment and assess the likely consequences of alternative tactics, including the prospects for mobilization, repression, elite defections, and policy concessions. The underlying assumption is that dissident organizations are more likely to adopt the tactic they expect to offer the greatest probability of achieving their political objectives. The following paragraphs summarize key political opportunities that shape the relative attractiveness of nonviolent and violent resistance.

A nonviolent campaign is a large-scale collective effort that uses nonviolent methods to achieve major political goal. Such goals may include overthrowing an incumbent government or achieving territorial secession. Common tactics include strikes, boycotts, and sit-ins. Nonviolent campaigns rely on broad participation and cooperation from large segments of society. Their effectiveness therefore depends on their ability to mobilize supporters, disrupt normal political activity and weaken the regime's sources of support.

As nonviolent resistance depends on mass participation, repression can substantially reduce its effectiveness. Arrests, violence, and intimidation increase the costs of participation and may discourage potential supporters from joining collective action (). Repression can also disrupt organizational networks by targeting leaders and activists who coordinate protest activities (). [Paper] showed that a key mechanism through which nonviolent campaigns succeed is by inducing defections among regime supporters. When political elites, bureaucrats, or members of the security forces withdraw their support from the incumbent government, the regime's capacity to govern and repress dissent is weakened ().

In addition to limiting repression, regimes may choose to negotiate or make concessions in response to nonviolent mobilization. When dissidents expect that peaceful collective action can generate meaningful concessions, the expected benefits of nonviolent tactics increase relative to violent alternatives. Nonviolent resistance is therefore most attractive when dissidents expect high levels of participation, a substantial likelihood of elite or security-force defections, limited repression, and a reasonable prospect of political concessions.

Violent campaigns involve the use of armed force or coercive violence to achieve large political objectives. Unlike nonviolent campaigns, violent resistance does not depend on broad participation in the same way and can be sustained by smaller, more centralized organizations. Because violent campaigns do not rely on mass mobilization, they may become relatively more attractive when conditions make large-scale participation in nonviolent resistance difficult. In particular, severe repression can raise the costs of open collective action, reducing the feasibility of sustained nonviolent mobilization.

Violent resistance may also be more likely when opportunities for elite or security-force defection are limited. When regimes maintain cohesive ruling coalitions and reliable coercive institutions, nonviolent campaigns are less able to generate the defections that often undermine incumbent governments. Consequently, political environments characterized by strong elite cohesion, effective repression, and low prospects for defection tend to increase the relative attractiveness of violent forms of resistance.

# Ethnic Composition and Campaign Tactic

Political opportunities play a central role in shaping whether dissident campaigns adopt violent or nonviolent strategies. Campaigns evaluate their prospects of success based on expectations about elite defections, repression, and political concessions, and choose the tactic that appears most likely to achieve their objectives.

This study argues that variation in these political opportunities is structured by the ethnic composition of ruling elites. Ethnic fragmentation shapes elite cohesion and thereby influences the likelihood of defection, the effectiveness of repression, and the probability of concessions. Ethnically heterogeneous ruling coalitions are more vulnerable to elite defection because political loyalty is often embedded in ethnic networks that provide alternative bases of support outside the regime. This increases the likelihood that elites withdraw support under conditions of sustained mobilization.

Ethnic divisions can also weaken coercive capacity by generating coordination problems within security forces and governing institutions, reducing the state's ability to carry out sustained repression. In addition, fragmented ruling coalitions may be more likely to pursue negotiated settlements, as internal divisions increase the risks associated with prolonged conflict and make concessions a more attractive option for regime survival.

Taken together, ethnic fragmentation increases the likelihood of elite defections, weakens repression, and increases the probability of concessions. These conditions make nonviolent resistance more effective relative to violent forms of contention. Accordingly, we expect that dissident campaigns facing more ethnically fragmented ruling coalitions will be more likely to adopt nonviolent tactics.

**Hypothesis 1.** *Greater ethnic fragmentation in ruling elites increases the likelihood that dissident campaigns adopt nonviolent tactics rather than violent tactics.*

Variation in political opportunities may also arise from differences in the distribution of power among ethnic groups within ruling coalitions. More equally powerful groups possess greater autonomy and capacity to defect, making elite cohesion weaker than in systems dominated by a single group.

Greater equality in the distribution of power among ethnic groups therefore increases the likelihood of elite defection and reduces the effectiveness of repression.

From this mechanism, I derive a second hypothesis:

**Hypothesis 2.** *Greater equality in the distribution of power among ethnic groups in the ruling elite increases the likelihood that dissident campaigns adopt nonviolent tactics.*

# Data and Methods

## Data description

Our study employs a panel dataset of 341 so-called "maximalist campaigns", a concept first introduced by Chenoweth and Stephan in *Why Civil Resistance Works* book (Chenoweth and Stephan 2011). Following their definition, a campaign is "a series of observable, continuous, purposive mass tactics or events in pursuit of a political objective', with maximalist objectives encompassing regime change, self-determination, secession, and the expulsion of foreign occupations (Chenoweth and Shay 2019). We rely on Nonviolent and Violent Campaigns and Outcomes (NAVCO) 2.1 dataset, which records 384 maximalist campaigns from 1945 to

2013[1].

The central conceptual distinction is between violent and nonviolent repertoires of contention. Following NAVCO coding rules, nonviolent tactics 'do not directly threaten or harm the physical wellbeing of the regime, its agents, or its citizens' and the violent repertoire 'involves the use of force to physically harm or threaten to harm the opponents' (Chenoweth and Shay 2019). The categories are mutually exclusive. A prominent example of a nonviolent campaign is the German 1989 *Die Wende* and the Cuban Revolution exemplifies a violent campaign. The violence/nonviolence distinction is well-established in the peace science literature and some significant findings have been made using NAVCO dataset (Celestino and Gleditsch 2013; Manekin and Mitts 2022; Cunningham 2013). Violence is operationally coded as a binary variable (1 = a campaign takes a violent form, 0 = a campaign takes a nonviolent form).

Our key independent variables are drawn from the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) Core Dataset (Vogt et al. 2015). EPR provides information on ethnic groups and their relative access to power. Following Hendrix and Salehyan (2019), we operationalize the ethnic ruling elite fragmentation via the *Included fractionalization index* (IFI) and the *Excluded fractionalization index* (EFI). IFI is "a Herfindahl-like index of all groups counted as 'included' (i.e. having access to executive power) during a given country-year", whilst EFI is "a Herfindahl-like index

[1]The most significant reason why the number of campaigns we have in the panel dataset differs from the total number of maximalist campaigns concerns country coding. We construct a panel dataset of indepedent country-years based on Correlates of War (CoW) list of independent states. We merge our panel data using NAVCO-assigned CoW country codes. However, in some cases, countries of a campaign location are not independent at the campaign onset year and thus lost from the data we use in the analysis. For example, there is a campaign geographically located in Algeria in 1952, though Algeria gained independence only in 1962. Even though a `countrycode` package matches Algeria with is country code, there is no available data on ethnic groups for Algeria until 1962. A naive solution would be assigning socio-economic characteristics of the "target" country - France in case of Algeria, though it would severely bias the results as if the campaign took place in France. We partly address this issue by excluding territorial campaigns in the robustness check section. Table F.1 in Appendix F lists all these lost campaigns.

of all groups counted as 'excluded' during a given country-year". Thus, a higher IFI indicates a more concentrated ethnic ruling elite and a lower IFI shows that ethnic power is distributed more equally, across many groups. Instead of relying on raw counts, IFI and EFI are more theoretically motivated. If a raw count treats two countries with the ethnic groups in power count of, say, 3 equally, IFI and EFI account for ethnic power distributions.

The Included Fractionalization Index (IFI) is calculated the following way:

$$IFI = 1 - \sum_{i=1}^{N} s_i^2$$

where $s_i$ is the population share of included ethnic group (i)[2]. Higher values indicate more fragmented ruling coalitions, while lower values indicate that executive power is concentrated among fewer ethnic groups.

For Hypothesis 2, we use a binary indicator derived from the highest EPR access-to-power category to distinguish between concentrated and shared executive power (Vogt et al. 2015; Hlatky and Landry 2025). For each campaign, the variable is coded as 1 if the highest status held by any politically relevant ethnic group is Senior Partner, indicating a meaningful power-sharing arrangement where executive authority is shared among multiple groups. It is coded as 0 if the highest status is Monopoly (exclusive control by a single group) or Dominant (one group controls the executive while others hold subordinate positions).

To address endogeneity and block non-causal paths, we control for a standard set of confounders: GDP per capita in constant PPP dollars (Gapminder 2024); logged population size (Nations 2024); executive corruption scores and polyarchy (electoral democracy) scores

[2]EFI follows an analogous construction, where $s_i$ would be the population share of excluded ethnic groups.

(Coppedge et al. 2024); regime duration in years (Coppedge et al. 2024); peace years (years elapsed since the last maximalist campaign in each country). Our theory focuses on pre-onset strategic decisions about campaign tactics. We therefore use one-year lagged values of all independent variables to capture the political environment in which these decisions are made.[3].

We also include the Excluded Fractionalization Index (EFI), constructed analogously to IFI but using the population shares of excluded ethnic groups rather than included groups. This controls for ethnic heterogeneity among excluded populations, ensuring that effects attributed to ruling coalition fragmentation are not confounded by broader ethnic structure. Finally, we control for whether a campaign is initiated by an included ethnic group to ensure that results are not driven by systematic differences between campaigns initiated by included versus excluded groups.

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics for all variables, separately for violent and nonviolent campaigns. The table shows a slight balance between violence and nonviolence instances. In the raw means, violent campaigns exhibit slightly higher levels of ethnic elite fragmentation (IFI) and more inclusive ethnic power-sharing arrangements within the executive compared to nonviolent campaigns.

Missing data is limited and does not pose a systematic concern for the analysis. In total, only 7.33% of IFI values and 13.2% of EPR highest access-to-power observations are missing[4]. Figure 1 shows the distribution of the included fractionalization index with respect to the tactic choice, visualized by both a histogram and a density plot. At low IFI values, nonviolent tactics are more frequent and with the growing IFI the violent tactic is prevalent. Moreover,

[3]Even though we find it unconvincing that a choice of one tactic over the other could affect IFI and EFI.

[4]There is missing data on ethnic groups for all campaigns in some countries where data collection is complicated and ethnic lines are profound, such as Yemen and Somalia.

with the growing IFI both tactic choices occur more frequently, reflecting the mass anti-regime mobilization logic - with the growing elite fragmentation, political opportunities of rebellion are increasing, regardless of the repertoire of contention. This visualization shows some degree of variation of 1) the Included Fractionaliztion Index 2) between violent and nonviolent choice.

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics by Campaign Tactics (NAVCO 2.1 Onsets)

| | Nonviolent (N=156) | | Violent (N=185) | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Mean | Std. Dev. | Mean | Std. Dev. |
| **Main Variables** | | | | |
| Included Fractionalization Index | 0.60 | 0.32 | 0.71 | 0.29 |
| Executive Power Sharing | 0.35 | 0.48 | 0.48 | 0.50 |
| **Control Variables** | | | | |
| Excluded Fractionalization Index | 0.95 | 0.12 | 0.92 | 0.16 |
| Ethnic Group in Power Participation | 0.08 | 0.28 | 0.09 | 0.29 |
| ln(GDP per capita) | 8.66 | 0.89 | 7.98 | 0.94 |
| ln(Population) | 9.75 | 1.69 | 9.81 | 1.57 |
| Polyarchy | 0.30 | 0.18 | 0.26 | 0.17 |
| Executive Corruption | 0.61 | 0.24 | 0.63 | 0.25 |
| ln(Regime Duration) | 2.25 | 1.25 | 1.72 | 1.25 |
| Peace Years | 15.46 | 14.90 | 9.79 | 10.96 |

*Note:* All variables are one-year lagged. Included Fractionalization Index (IFI): Higher values indicate greater fragmentation among included ethnic groups. Executive Power Sharing (binary): 1 = shared executive authority among ethnic groups, 0 = indicate concentrated executive control.

## Modeling approach

Because the dependent variable captures whether a campaign onset is violent or nonviolent, we estimate logistic regression models. The focus of the analysis is on the choice of tactic at campaign onset, rather than the timing or duration of campaigns; a binary logit specification is therefore appropriate. As we do not predict the duration of events, there is no need for advanced binary choice models such as a complementary log-log.

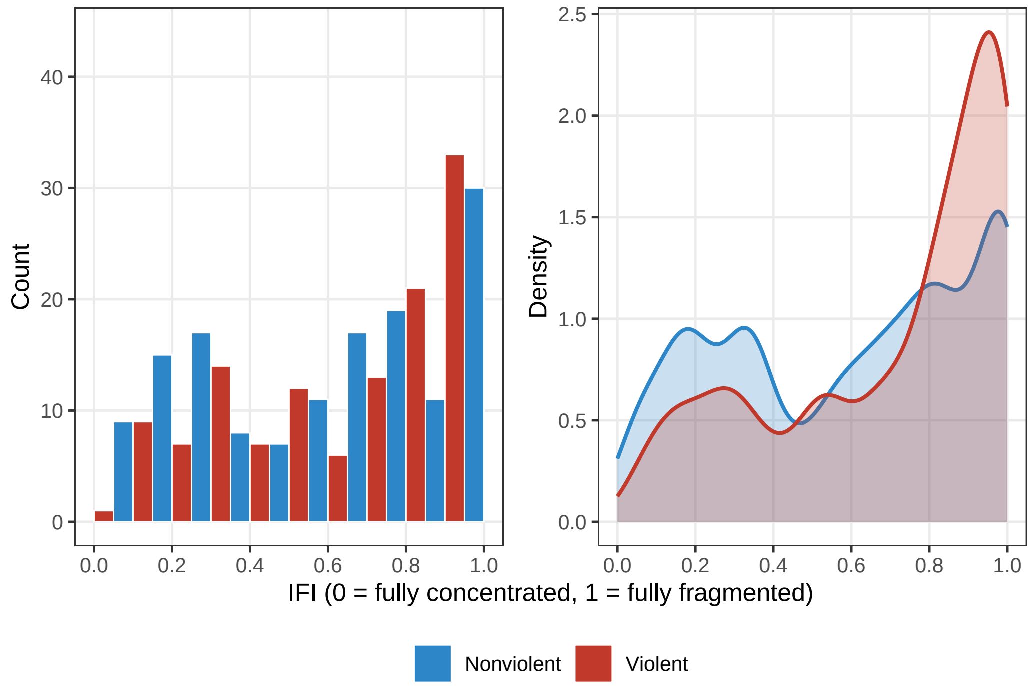


Figure 1: Included fractionalization index by repertoire choice: a histogram and a density plot

To account for the panel structure of the data - where multiple campaign onsets may occur within the same country - we include country-level varying intercepts. This allows baseline differences in the propensity toward violent versus nonviolent campaign onset to vary across countries.

Including a country fixed effect to control for the time-invariant unobserved factors such as culture or geography is theoretically appealing and common in the peace science literature (Butcher and Svensson 2016; Ives and Breslawski 2022; Fearon and Laitin 2003; Jung 2025). Ethnic configurations change slowly over time, and exploratory analysis indicates limited within-country variation in both IFI and EFI. As a result, a fixed-effects specification would rely primarily on the relatively small subset of countries that experience meaningful changes in ethnic inclusion structures across campaign onsets. Given that our theoretical argument concerns how both cross-national differences and temporal variation in elite ethnic structures shape strategic choices, we retain both sources of variation. A random-intercepts specification is therefore more consistent with the structure of the data and the substantive scope of the hypotheses.

We acknowledge, however, that random-effects models rely on a stronger assumption than fixed effects—namely that country-specific unobserved heterogeneity is uncorrelated with the included regressors. If this assumption is violated, coefficient estimates may be biased (Clark and Linzer 2015). Despite this limitation, the random-intercepts approach represents an appropriate trade-off between bias and efficiency in this setting, given the limited within-country variation in key predictors. To assess the sensitivity of our results to this assumption, we follow Bell and Jones (2015) and estimate an alternative Within-Between Random Effect (REWB) model specification as a robustness check.

For Hypothesis 1, our model specification is:

$$
\begin{aligned}
&\text{violent}_{it} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\pi_{it}) \\
&\log\left(\frac{\pi_{it}}{1-\pi_{it}}\right) = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{IFI})_{it-1} + \beta_2(\text{EFI})_{it-1} + \mathbf{X}'_{it-1}\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \alpha_{[j]i} \\
&\alpha_j \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_\alpha, \sigma^2_\alpha)
\end{aligned}
$$

where $\mathbf{X}_{it-1}$ denotes the vector of lagged control variables and $u_i$ is a country-specific random intercept capturing unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity.

For Hypothesis 2, our model specification is:

$$\text{violent}_{it} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\pi_{it})$$

$$\log\left(\frac{\pi_{it}}{1-\pi_{it}}\right) = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{Senior Partner})_{it-1} + \beta_2(\text{EFI})_{it-1} + \mathbf{X}'_{it-1}\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \alpha_{[j]i}$$

$$\alpha_j \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_\alpha, \sigma^2_\alpha)$$

where Senior Partner is a binary indicator of whether the highest status held by any politically relevant ethnic group is Senior Partner, $\mathbf{X}_{it-1}$ denotes the vector of lagged control variables and $u_i$ is a country-specific random intercept capturing unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity.

For uncertainty calculations, we follow a King's simulation approach (King, Tomz, and Wittenberg 2000). This approach is also well-established in peace science literature (Butcher and Svensson 2016). Instead of reporting coefficients and their significance, we calculate predicted probabilities as the main quantity of interest via an observed value approach (OVA), meaning we simulate the predicted probabilities for all observations and then calculate the mean of them[5]. We simulate over the full available range of the vocal variable values. For the essay, we define `sim_ova_range` function for the OVA simulations, allowing to calculate predicted probabilities in just few lines of code. We also define a `sim_ova_fd` function, allowing to calculate simulated first differences. It also allows for different CI levels, seeds, number of values and focal variable ranges at the researcher's discretion.

[5]We report coefficients only in the cross-validation robustness check.

# Results

## Hypothesis 1

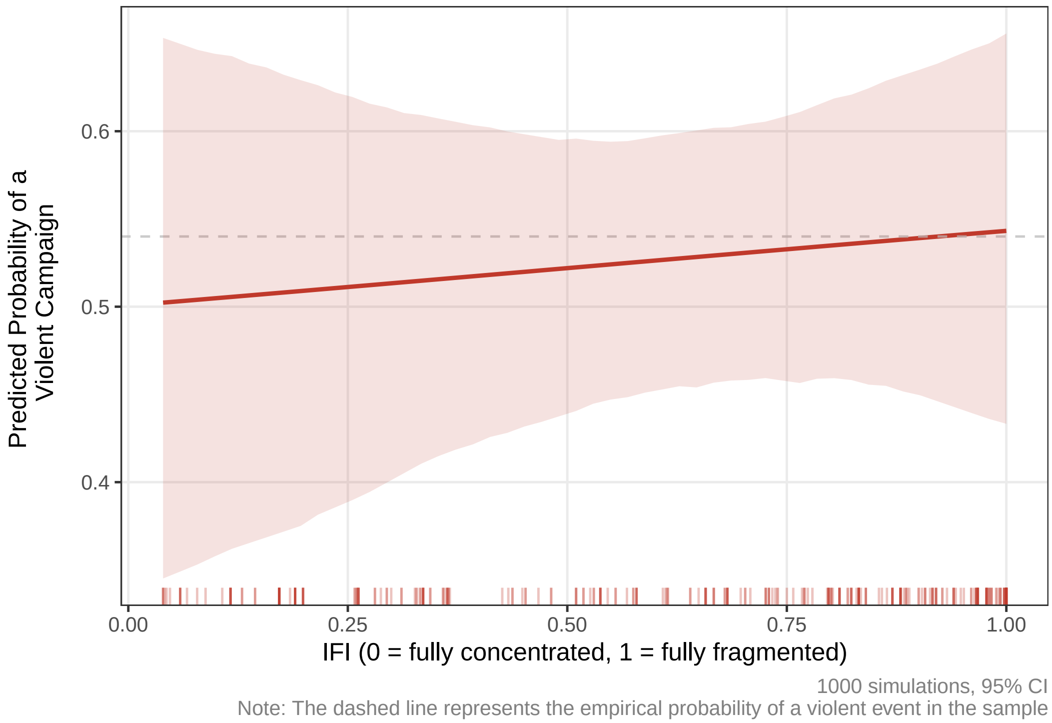


Figure 2: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of included fractionalization index values

To test the first hypothesis, we estimate a logit model of the violent tactic choice, according to the H1 model specification[6]. Figure 2 shows the simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a full available range of observed IFI values. Despite a upward trend - from 0.5 at IFI equal to 0.04 to 0.54 at IFI equal to 1 - confidence intervals that encompass 0.54, which is the empirical probability of a violent campaign, do not allow us to claim that with the increasing IFI the rebels would prefer violence over nonviolence.

Despite an insignificant effect of IFI on a violent choice, the model as a whole demonstrates

[6]Regression coefficients are available in Table C.1 in Appendix C

Table 2: Confusion Matrix and Predictive Performance — Model 1

| | **Actual Nonviolent** | **Actual Violent** |
|---|---|---|
| **Confusion Matrix** | | |
| Predicted Nonviolent | 21 | 7 |
| Predicted Violent | 15 | 31 |
| **Performance Metrics** | | |
| Accuracy | 0.703 | |
| Precision | 0.674 | |
| Recall | 0.816 | |
| F1 Score | 0.738 | |
| AUC | 0.826 | |

a strong predictive performance. Model fit was evaluated using out-of-sample prediction. A train-test split mode reestimation was employed to calculate classification accuracy, precision, recall, F1 scores, and the area under the receiver operating characteristic curve (AUC). Table 2 reports the confusion matrix and performance metrics. With an accuracy of 0.7 and F1 score of 0.74, our model in general predicts tactic choice well above a coin toss, predicting violence a bit better than the nonviolent choice. Another measure of model fit is the area under the ROC curve (AUC), showing whether our model predictions of a violent choice are better than a random draw. The AUC score of 0.83 indicates a good model fit. Figure A.1 in Appendix A plots an AUC-ROC curve for this model. An important implication here is that the model as a whole (including the specification itself, a set of covariates and a country varying intercept) captures meaningful variation in the outcome, even though the IFI does not significantly predict a violent choice. Such results reflect a real absence of the IFI effect rather than a model misspecification.

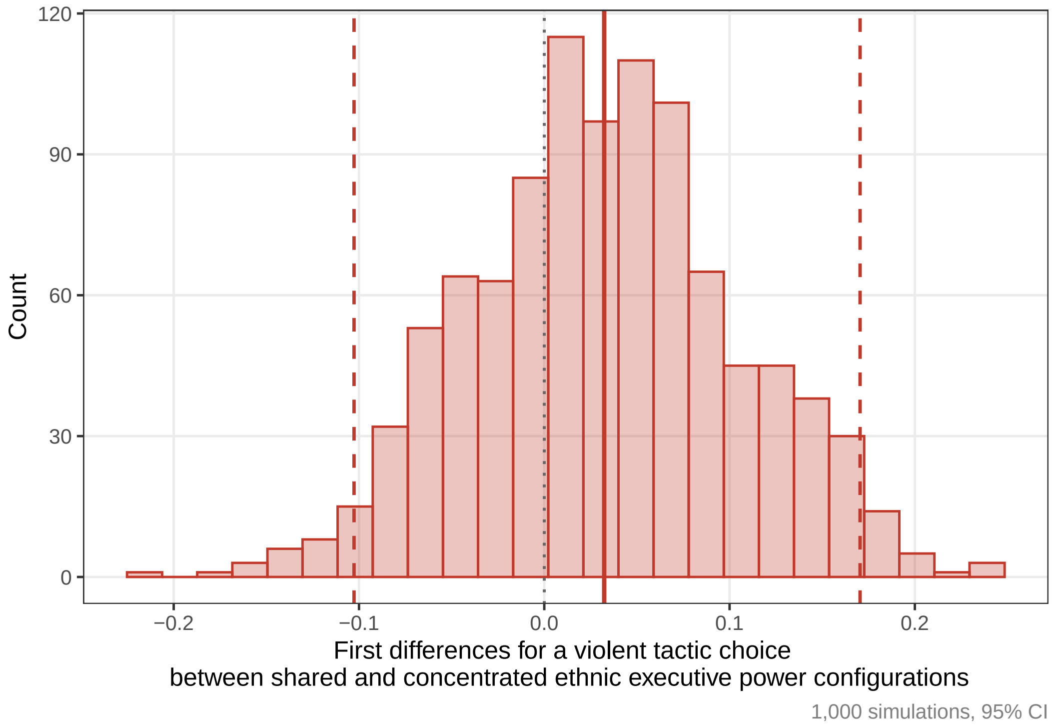


Figure 3: Simulated first differences for a violent tactic choice between shared and concentrated ethnic executive power

## Hypothesis 2

To test the second hypothesis, we estimate a logit model of the violent tactic choice, according to the H2 model specification[7]. Given the binary independent variable, we calculated simulated first differences according to the observed value approach. Figure 3 shows the simulated first differences of a violent tactic choice between the shared (`epr_highest_rank` = 1) and concentrated (`epr_highest_rank` = 0) ethnic executive power configurations. The results clearly indicate that, despite a positive mean value of the first differences, there are no systematic and statistically significant differences between the effects of shared and concentrated ethnic executive power on the violent tactic choice. It contrasts with theoretical

[7]Initially, the model did not converge with the `bobyqa` optimizer. Following Bates et al. (2015), we reestimate the model with all the available optimizers. Then, we pick the model with the highest log-likelihood value among the converged models. As a result of such reesimation, we use the converged model for simulating first differences. Regression coefficients are available in Table C.1 in Appendix C.

expectations where ethnic power-sharing arrangements could push the dissidents towards one repertoire of contention over the other.

Table 3: Confusion Matrix and Predictive Performance — Model 2

| | **Actual Nonviolent** | **Actual Violent** |
|---|---|---|
| **Confusion Matrix** | | |
| Predicted Nonviolent | 15 | 5 |
| Predicted Violent | 14 | 29 |
| **Performance Metrics** | | |
| Accuracy | 0.698 | |
| Precision | 0.674 | |
| Recall | 0.853 | |
| F1 Score | 0.753 | |
| AUC | 0.796 | |

As well as with the model 1, we test the model fit using out-of-sample prediction. Table 3 reports the confusion matrix and performance metrics. All the metrics, especially F1 Score and AUC, indicate a good model fit as well. According to the confusion matrix, the model predicts violent tactic choice particularly successfully. Figure B.1 in Appendix B plots an AUC-ROC curve for this model. In general, both models successfully capture meaningful variation in the outcome.

## Assumption Diagnostics

A series of diagnostic tests were conducted for the models of both hypotheses. Variance inflation factors indicated no evidence of multicollinearity among the explanatory variables. The assumption of linearity on the logit scale was assessed by comparing the baseline specifications to models including natural spline terms for the main explanatory variables. As the spline specifications did not improve model fit, the linear specifications were retained.

Furthermore, DHARMa residual diagnostics, including quantile and QQ-plot assessments, revealed no substantial deviations from model expectations and provided no evidence of serious misspecification. Influence diagnostics based on Cook's distance indicated that the results were not driven by a small number of influential observations. Detailed diagnostic results are reported in Appendix D (Tables D.1–D.4 and Figures D.1-D.4).

## Robustness Checks

We conduct four robustness checks to assess the stability of the findings[8]. First, given that civil conflicts and a tactic choice are regionally clustered, we estimate an additional model on the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) and Sub-Saharan Africa countries subsample, where violent campaigns are more expected than in other regions. For the full sample, there are 54.3% of violent campaigns, whilst for MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa there are 65.5% of them. Second, following Bell and Jones (2015), we estimate an alternative Within-Between Random Effect (REWB) model specification. REWB presents a main independent variable in two forms: its demeaned form and a group mean. De-meaning allows to estimate a *within* (essentially fixed) effect and save the underlying assumption of the varying intercept model. Finally, simulation-based cross-validation was employed to assess the stability of coefficient estimates across repeated subsamples. Across these alternative specifications and samples, the substantive conclusions remained unchanged, providing additional confidence in the robustness of the findings.

Figure 4 displays the results of regional subsampling robustness checks. For a Model

[8]An important note here is that we do not compare the model fit of these specifications because of the different samples, which make the models incomparable in terms of model fit measures.

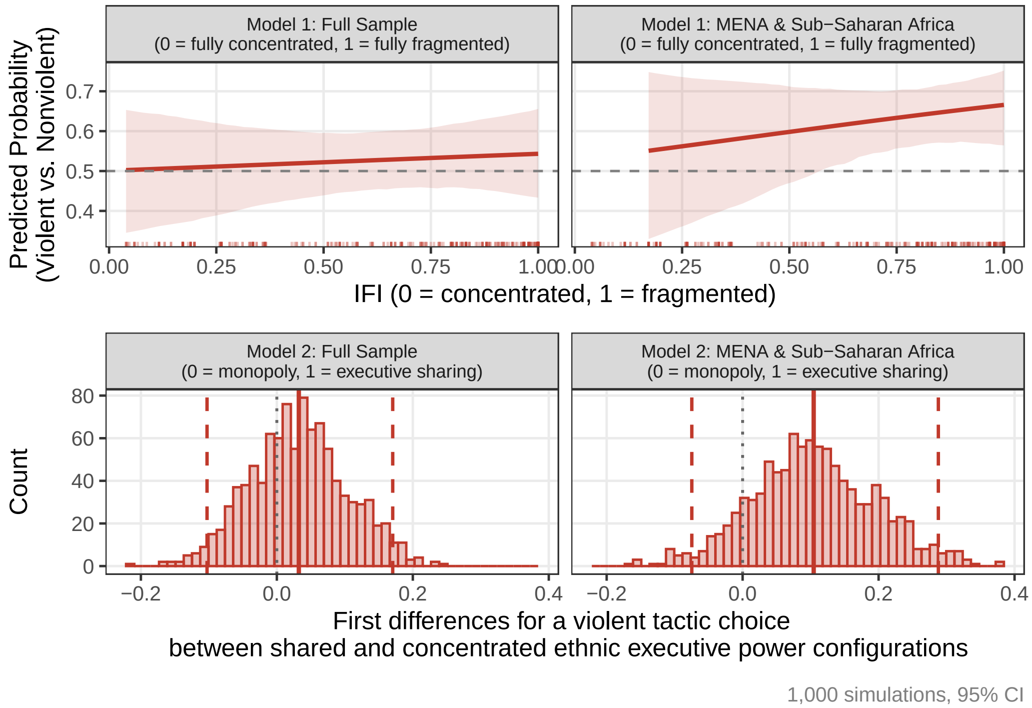


Figure 4: Simulated first differences for a violent tactic choice between shared and concentrated ethnic executive power

1 robustness check, the IFI coefficient remains insignificant, though the effect of the IFI on the violent choice is much stronger. The confidence intervals stay above the empirical probability of the violent choice across most of the IFI range, proving our assumption that in specific regions the effect of the IFI is more pronounced and better identified. For a Model 2 robustness check, the mean first difference is slightly shifted rightward, though the confidence intervals cross zero as well as in the full sample, suggesting the robustness of the H2 findings.

Figure 5 plots the simulated predicted probabilities over the full range of IFI values for both RE and REWB models (Hypothesis 1). A slight upward trend with confidence intervals crossing the empirical probability of a violent tactic choice for both models suggests the robustness of the findings. You can find a first differences plot between RE and REWB models in Figure E.1 in Appendix E.

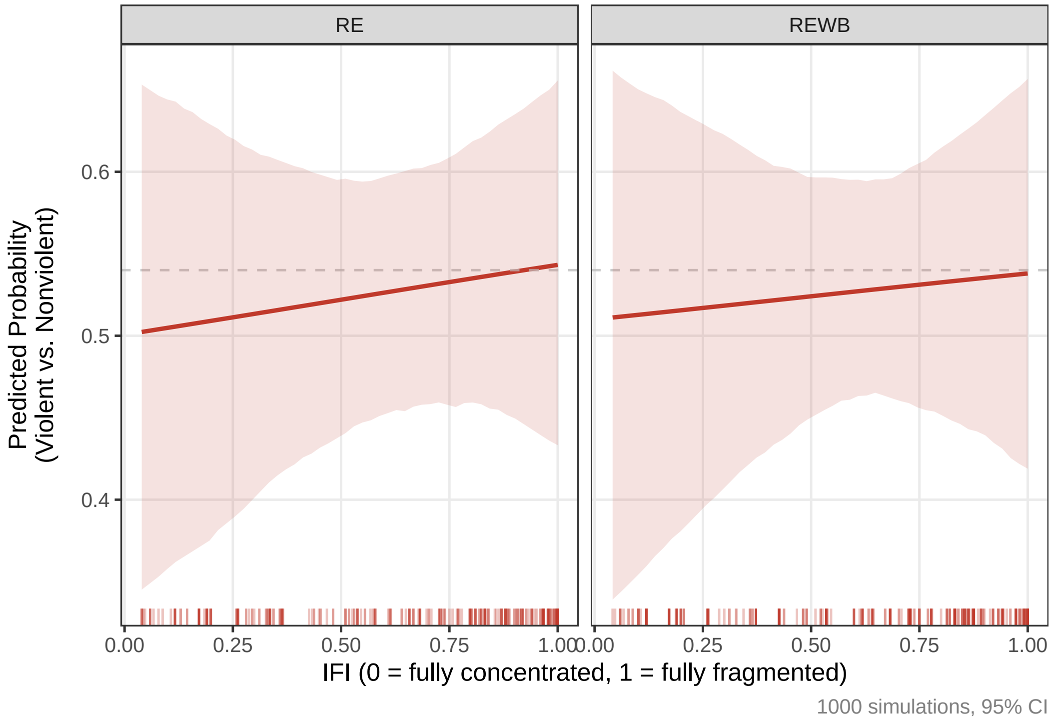


Figure 5: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of IFI values - baseline vs. REWB

Finally, we cross-validate the results (5 cross-validations) to check whether the same results hold when models are estimated on different random subsamples. For this, we define the `cross_validation_fun` function[9]. For this part, we did not calculate quantities of interest, but rather compare coefficient values and their significance, which will be enough to judge whether the results are stable or not. Table **??** shows the coefficients differences between the main and the cross-validated model. For both models, the IFI coefficient is negative and insignificant, though the coefficient absolute values differ. Moreover, one could notice a slight inflation of the standard errors, though not significantly changing the null result. Moreover, the reader should account for the sample size and respective test sample sizes that partly

[9]Cross-validation subsampling causes convergence issues due to low sample sizes of the subsamples. To address this, we force the function to resample and reestimate the model until convergence. Thus, it can take more than one attempt to estimate one cross-validated subsample. It took 9 attempts for Model 1 and 10 for Model 2 to estimate 5 cross-validations

explain standard errors' inflation.

## Conclusion

Why do some dissident movements choose violence while others pursue nonviolent resistance? This paper examined whether part of the answer lies in the ethnic composition of ruling elites. Building on political opportunity theories, we argued that ethnic fragmentation and a more equal distribution of power among ruling ethnic groups could weaken elite cohesion, increase the likelihood of defections, reduce the effectiveness of repression, and make concessions more likely. These conditions were expected to increase the attractiveness of nonviolent resistance relative to violent tactics.

Using data on maximalist campaigns from the NAVCO 2.1 project and measures of ethnic power relations from the EPR dataset, we tested whether ethnic elite composition influences campaign tactic choice. The empirical results provide little support for this argument. Neither ethnic fragmentation among ruling elites nor the distribution of power across ruling ethnic groups consistently predicts whether dissidents adopt violent or nonviolent tactics. Moreover, these null findings remain robust across alternative model specifications and subsamples.

These findings are relevant because they challenge a plausible extension of political opportunity theory. Existing research suggests that elite defections, repression, and concessions are important determinants of campaign success and strategic choice. If ethnic fragmentation affects these mechanisms, one might expect it to shape campaign tactics as well. The results presented here suggest that this connection is weaker than anticipated. While ethnic divisions within ruling coalitions may influence regime stability, conflict dynamics, or campaign outcomes, they do not appear to systematically affect the initial choice between violent and nonviolent resistance.

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# Appendix

## Appendix A: AUC - ROC Curve - Model 1

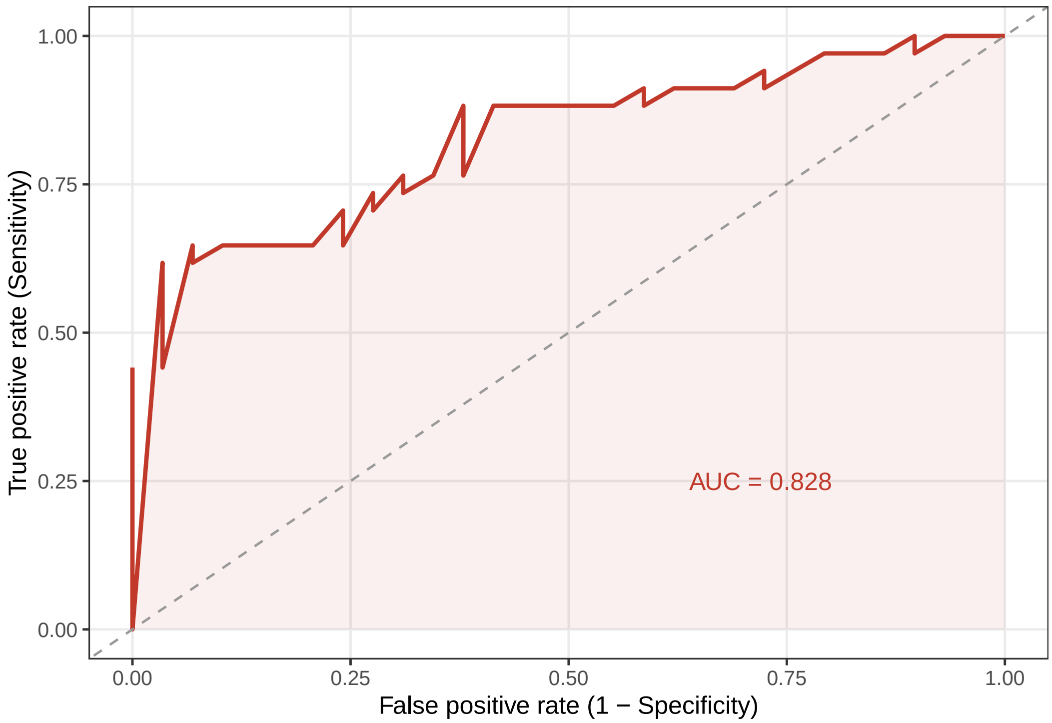


Figure A.1: AUC-ROC Curve - Model 1

## Appendix B: AUC - ROC Curve - Model 2

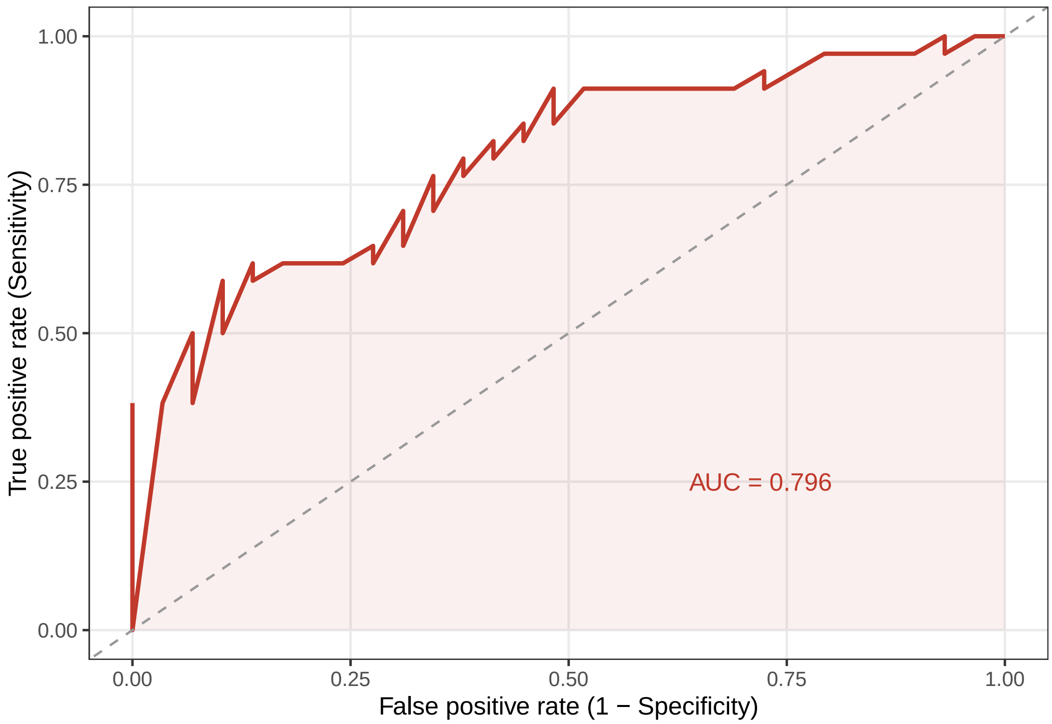


Figure B.1: AUC-ROC Curve - Model 2

## Appendix C: Model 1 and 2 regression coefficients

Table C.1: Mixed-Effects Logistic Regression Models

| | H1 | H2 |
|---|---|---|
| IFI | 0.194 | |
| | (0.721) | |
| Executive Power Sharing | | 0.175 |
| | | (0.382) |
| EFI | −1.634 | −1.675 |
| | (1.582) | (1.405) |
| Ethnic Group in Power Participation | −0.086 | −0.162 |
| | (0.529) | (0.510) |
| ln(GDP per capita) | −0.951*** | −0.775*** |
| | (0.260) | (0.233) |
| ln(Population) | −0.095 | −0.089 |
| | (0.138) | (0.126) |
| Polyarchy | 0.573 | 0.382 |
| | (1.047) | (1.044) |
| Executive Corruption | 0.159 | 0.197 |
| | (0.767) | (0.719) |
| ln(Regime Duration) | −0.293* | −0.289* |
| | (0.144) | (0.141) |
| Peace Years | −0.020 | −0.018 |
| | (0.014) | (0.014) |
| Num.Obs. | 297 | 266 |

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

*Note:* Standard errors are reported in parentheses. Country random intercepts are included in all models.

## Appendix D: Assumptions diagnostics

Table D.1: Variance Inflation Factors

| **Variable** | **H1** | **H2** |
|---|---|---|
| **Main Variables** | | |
| IFI | 1.38 | NA |
| Executive Power Sharing | NA | 1.21 |
| **Control Variables** | | |
| EFI | 1.24 | 1.15 |
| Ethnic Group in Power Participation | 1.10 | 1.13 |
| ln(GDP per capita) | 1.25 | 1.24 |
| ln(Population) | 1.17 | 1.14 |
| Polyarchy | 1.26 | 1.27 |
| Executive Corruption | 1.13 | 1.08 |
| ln(Regime Duration) | 1.22 | 1.20 |
| Peace Years | 1.35 | 1.35 |

*Note:* Variance Inflation Factors (VIFs) assess multicollinearity among predictors. Values close to 1 indicate negligible multicollinearity.

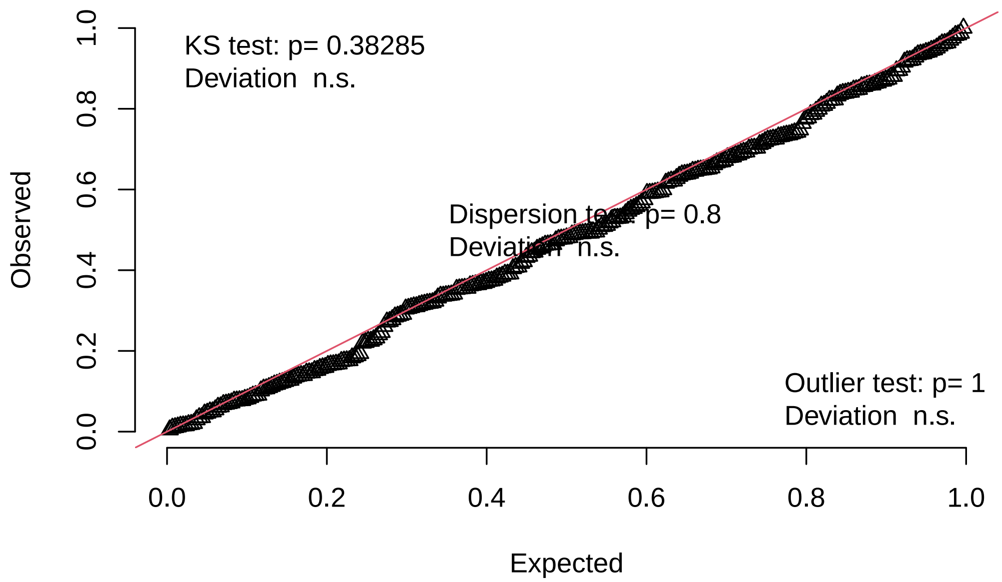


Figure D.1: Residual QQ plots (Model 1)

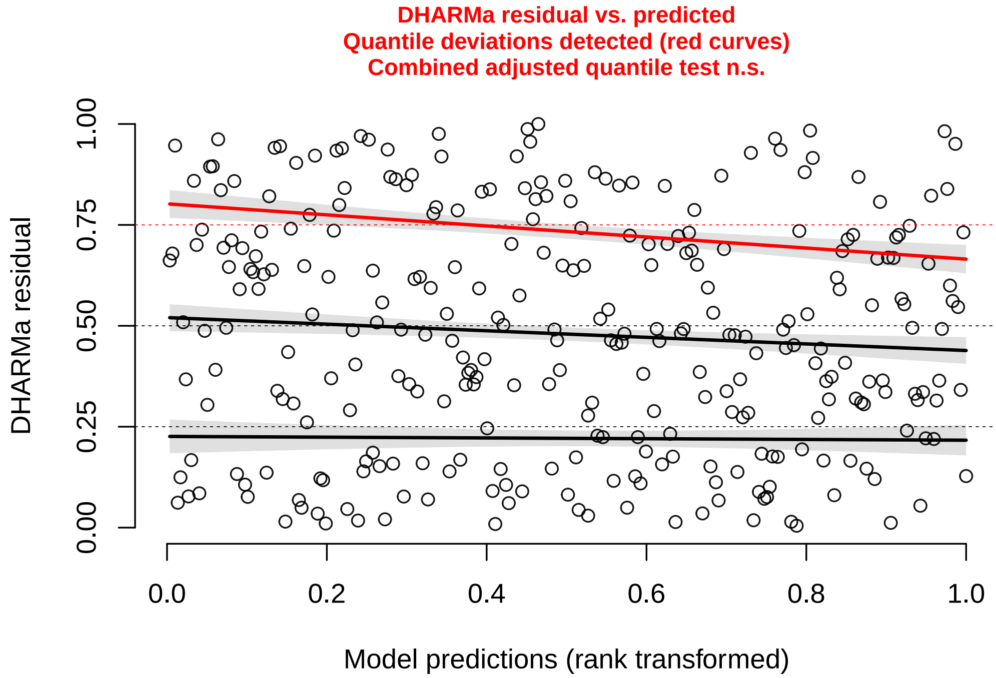


Figure D.2: DHARMa residual diagnostics (Model 1)

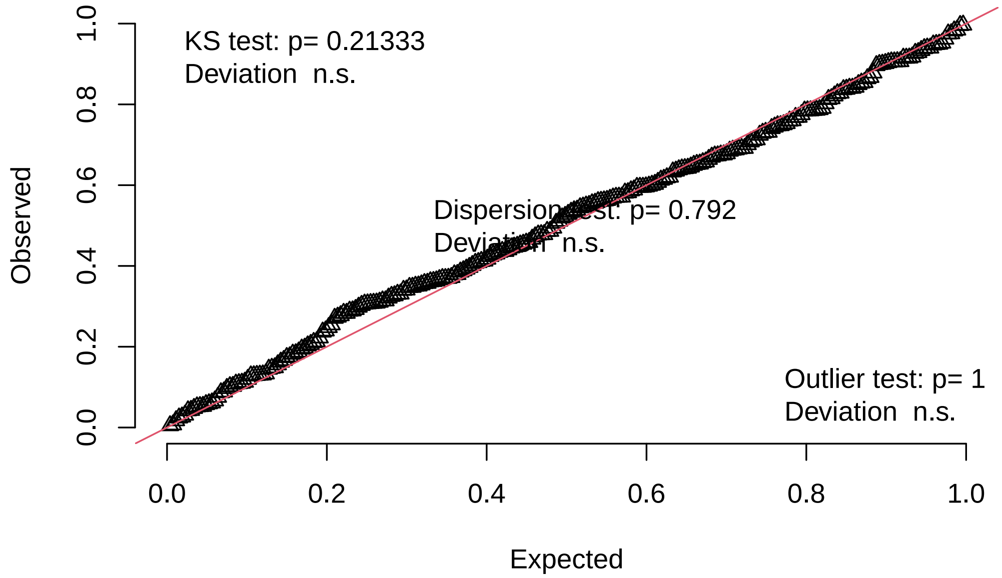


Figure D.3: Residual QQ plots (Model 2)

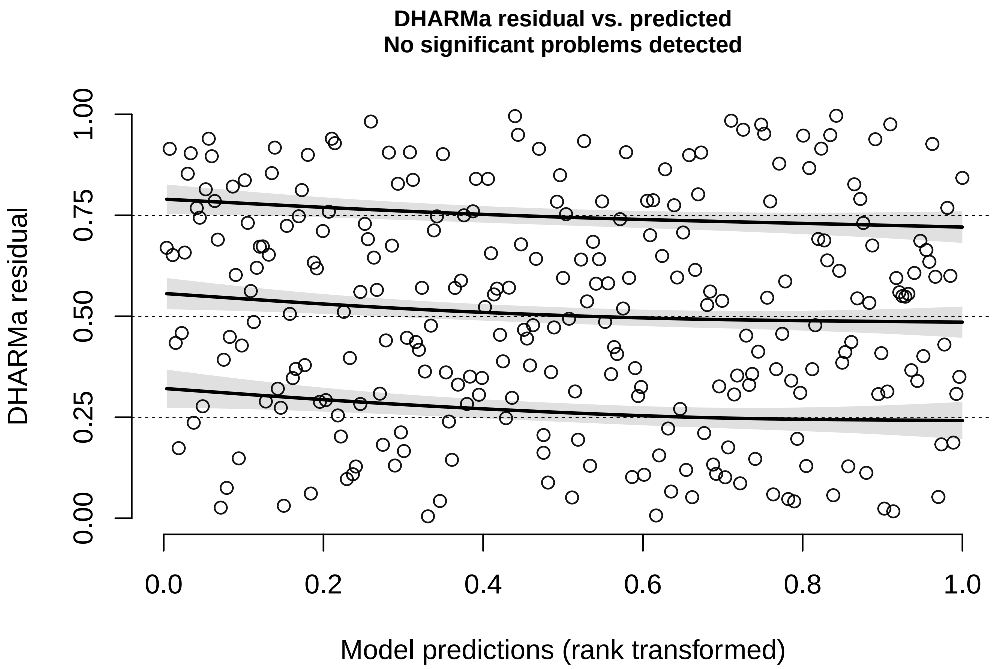


Figure D.4: DHARMa residual diagnostics (Model 2)

Table D.2: Logistic Models without Influential Outliers

| | H1 | H2 |
|---|---|---|
| IFI | 0.422 | |
| | (1.032) | |
| Executive Power Sharing | | 0.530 |
| | | (0.512) |
| EFI | −3.888 | −4.500 |
| | (2.735) | (2.470) |
| Ethnic Group in Power Participation | 0.074 | 0.157 |
| | (0.667) | (0.635) |
| ln(GDP per capita) | −1.543*** | −1.324*** |
| | (0.384) | (0.366) |
| ln(Population) | −0.207 | −0.219 |
| | (0.201) | (0.189) |
| Polyarchy | −0.062 | 0.653 |
| | (1.431) | (1.425) |
| Executive Corruption | 0.775 | 0.554 |
| | (1.085) | (1.008) |
| ln(Regime Duration) | −0.611** | −0.651** |
| | (0.205) | (0.210) |
| Peace Years | −0.038 | −0.027 |
| | (0.020) | (0.020) |
| Num.Obs. | 280 | 250 |

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

*Note:* Standard errors are reported in parentheses. Country random intercepts are included in all models.

Table D.3: Comparison of Baseline and Spline Specifications

| **Model** | **AIC** | **BIC** | **LogLik** |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Hypothesis 1** | | | |
| H1 Baseline | 368.6 | 409.2 | -173.3 |
| H1 Splines | 371.4 | 426.8 | -170.7 |
| **Hypothesis 2** | | | |
| H2 Baseline | 341.2 | 380.6 | -159.6 |
| H2 Splines | 342.2 | 388.8 | -158.1 |

*Note:* Spline models replace the focal explanatory variable with a natural spline specification (df = 3). Higher-order spline coefficients are omitted because they lack substantive interpretation. Model fit is evaluated using AIC and BIC.

Table D.4: Country-Level Random Intercept Variance

| | **Statistic** | **H1** | **H2** |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Country Intercept Variance | 1.344 | 0.763 |
| (Intercept) | Country Intercept SD | 1.160 | 0.874 |

*Note:* Reported values are estimates of the country-level random intercept variance and standard deviation. Non-zero variance indicates meaningful between-country heterogeneity.

## Appendix E: First Differences plot: RE and REWB models (Hypothesis 2)

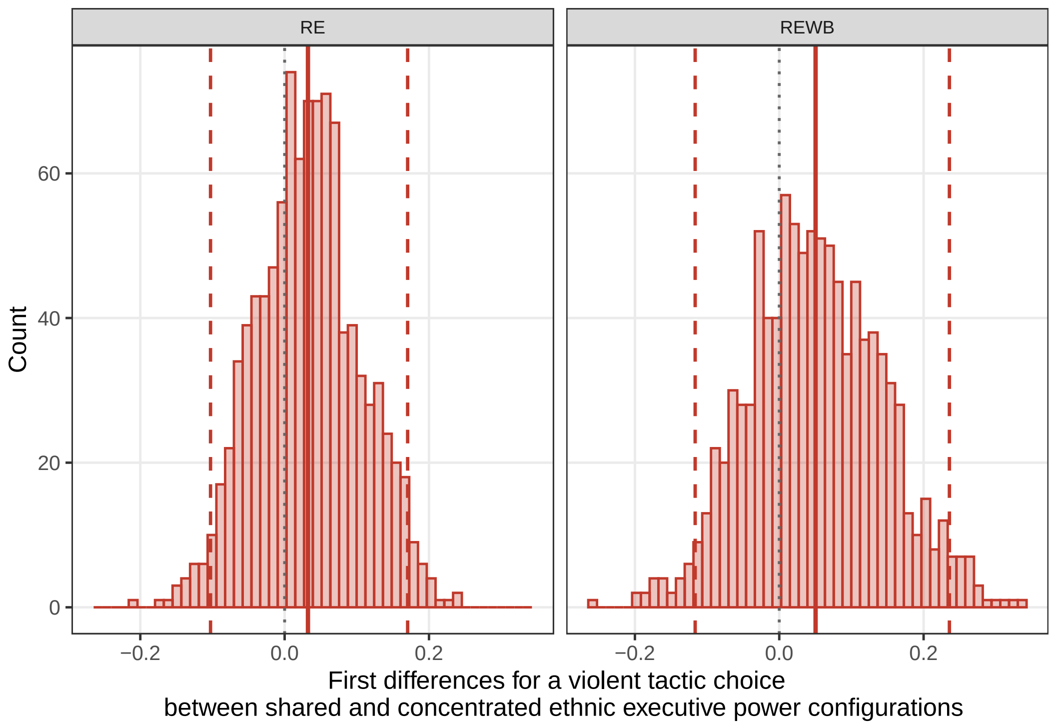


Figure E.1: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of IFI values - baseline vs. REWB

## Appendix F: Campaigns excluded from the empirical analysis due to country coding issues

Table F.1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample due to states panel coverage

| COW code | Year | Country |
|---|---|---|
| 615 | 1952 | Algeria |
| 540 | 1961 | Angola |
| 370 | 1988 | Belarus |
| 346 | 1991 | Bosnia & Herzegovina |
| 835 | 1962 | Brunei |
| 811 | 1946 | Cambodia |
| 471 | 1955 | Cameroon |
| 344 | 1991 | Croatia |
| 352 | 1954 | Cyprus |
| 315 | 1967 | Czechoslovakia |
| 315 | 1989 | Czechoslovakia |
| 531 | 1945 | Eritrea |
| 366 | 1945 | Estonia |
| 366 | 1987 | Estonia |
| 265 | 1953 | German Democratic Republic |

Table F.1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample due to states panel coverage *(continued)*

| **COW code** | **Year** | **Country** |
|---|---|---|
| 452 | 1948 | Ghana |
| 404 | 1963 | Guinea-Bissau |
| 750 | 1946 | India |
| 850 | 1945 | Indonesia |
| 501 | 1952 | Kenya |
| 703 | 1990 | Kyrgyzstan |
| 812 | 1946 | Laos |
| 812 | 1950 | Laos |
| 367 | 1945 | Latvia |
| 367 | 1989 | Latvia |
| 368 | 1945 | Lithuania |
| 368 | 1988 | Lithuania |
| 580 | 1947 | Madagascar |
| 553 | 1958 | Malawi |
| 820 | 1948 | Malaysia |
| 600 | 1953 | Morocco |
| 541 | 1963 | Mozambique |

Table F.1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample due to states panel coverage *(continued)*

| **COW code** | **Year** | **Country** |
|---|---|---|
| 565 | 1960 | Namibia |
| 475 | 1945 | Nigeria |
| 698 | 1964 | Oman |
| 517 | 1956 | Rwanda |
| 517 | 1961 | Rwanda |
| 317 | 1989 | Slovakia |
| 349 | 1991 | Slovenia |
| 713 | 1947 | Taiwan |
| 860 | 1975 | Timor-Leste |
| 616 | 1952 | Tunisia |
| 369 | 1990 | Ukraine |
| 816 | 1945 | Vietnam |
| 679 | 1948 | Yemen |
| 679 | 1955 | Yemen |
| 679 | 1960 | Yemen |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 551 | 1960 | Zambia |

*Note:* N = 48 campaigns. For the reasons of exclusion: see a footnote in the introduction